Preference, Restriction, Allergy or Doctor's Instruction?

A one-page sheet for sorting what you know about Dad's day: eighteen words and headings, each with what to note.

“Dad doesn't eat fish.” Is that a taste, a habit, or something his doctor told him? The family may not have the same answer. This sheet puts the categories a preferences page uses into plain words, with what to note for each.

The definitions are for sorting your notes and knowing what to ask. They aren't for deciding what Dad may or may not eat or do. That belongs to him and his clinicians.

The four that get mixed up, and how to keep them apart

Preference

Something Dad likes, dislikes or chooses: how he takes his coffee, when he eats, what he'd never order. It's his to state and his to change.

WRITE DOWN What he said, in his words, with the date.

Restriction

A limit on what he eats or does, as opposed to a like or a dislike. What matters is where it came from, and the family may not know.

WRITE DOWN The limit, who told you about it, and “source not sure” if that's the case.

Allergy

MedlinePlus describes a food allergy as an abnormal immune system reaction to certain foods. It is a medical matter, not a dislike. [1]

WRITE DOWN What the family has been told, and by whom. Whether it is an allergy is for his doctor to say.

Doctor's instruction

Something a doctor or another clinician treating Dad has told him to do or avoid, about food or anything else. It isn't a preference, and questions about it go back to whoever gave it.

WRITE DOWN Where it's written down, who gave it and when. Copy the wording; don't reword it.

Separate lists

Published forms keep these apart. The Alzheimer's Association's Personal Facts and Insights sheet has separate lines for special dietary needs, food allergies, favorite foods and strong dislikes. [2]

WRITE DOWN Each item on the list it belongs to. If you can't tell, put it under “not sure” and ask.

The headings on a preferences page

How he likes to be addressed

The name he'd want a new person to use: Mr. and his surname, his first name, a nickname. The Alzheimer's Association form asks for a preferred name as well as the person's name. [2]

WRITE DOWN The name, as he gave it.

A good day

An ordinary day he'd call a good one. The Conversation Project's workbook asks it as “What does a good day look like for you?” [3]

WRITE DOWN His description, in his words.

Morning and evening routines

How his day usually starts and ends, and in what order. The form's own example is having coffee and newspaper in the morning. [2]

WRITE DOWN The order, the rough times, and the parts he says matter.

Food preferences

What he likes to eat and when he usually eats it. Likes and dislikes only; restrictions are written down separately.

WRITE DOWN Favorites, dislikes and usual meal times, as he tells them.

Activities and relationships

What he does with his time and who he does it with. The Administration for Community Living lists recreation, friendships, family relationships and social activities among the preferences that person-centered planning takes in. [4]

WRITE DOWN What, when and with whom, and what he says it takes to keep doing it.

Communication preferences

How he likes to be reached and spoken with. The Alzheimer's Association suggests discussing which method is most comfortable, such as face-to-face conversation, email or phone calls. [5]

WRITE DOWN What he says works for him.

Cultural or religious preferences

Customs, observances or beliefs he wants respected. On this page they're the ones he brings up himself; the family doesn't fill them in for him.

WRITE DOWN What he tells you, as he tells it.

What helps him feel comfortable

Whatever settles him somewhere unfamiliar. The form asks it as “What is calming?” [2]

WRITE DOWN What he says helps, and what he says doesn't.

Source and review date

Who each note came from, and when it was written or last checked. The form ends with “Completed by” and “Date completed” lines. [2]

WRITE DOWN “Dad told me” or “my sister thinks,” the date, and when you've agreed to look again.

Words about the page itself

In his own words

His phrasing, kept as he said it instead of tidied into yours.

WRITE DOWN The sentence, in quotation marks.

Assumption

Something the family believes about Dad that he hasn't confirmed.

WRITE DOWN The belief and whose it is, marked confirmed, corrected or not yet asked.

Permission to share

Dad's say over who reads the page. The Conversation Project's workbook asks people how much they want those close to them to know. [3]

WRITE DOWN Who he's happy to have see it, at the bottom of the page.

Person-centered

The Administration for Community Living describes person-centered planning as a process directed by the person who receives the support. [4]

WRITE DOWN For each note, whether it came from Dad himself.

What this sheet doesn't do

It defines words and headings. It doesn't tell you which of them apply to Dad, whether anything is an allergy, or what any instruction means for him. That's for Dad and the clinicians who know him. The Alzheimer's Association form and communication page were written with dementia care in mind; only their everyday headings are used here, and nothing on this sheet assumes that applies to Dad.

Ready for the next step?

You can tell a preference from an instruction now, and you know what to note for each. The care interview uses the same headings in plain language: it takes Dad's preferences alongside the rest of his situation, one area at a time, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. MedlinePlus (National Library of Medicine), Food Allergy
2. Alzheimer's Association, Personal Facts and Insights (form)
3. The Conversation Project (Institute for Healthcare Improvement) and Ariadne Labs, What Matters to Me: A Workbook for Better Health Care
4. Administration for Community Living, Person-Centered Planning
5. Alzheimer's Association, Communication and Alzheimer's